
Exploration of the Frankincense Country, Southern Arabia: Discussion

Author(s): William Flower

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In conclusion, I must add that Imam Sharif Khan Bahadur, who accompanied us last year in the Hadramut, was again kindly placed at our disposal by the Indian Government, and was as before exceedingly useful to us in our various difficulties. To him we owe the maps of the Hadramut and Dhofar districts, and I am sure his regrets were equal to our own at not being able to join these two important surveys of Southern Arabia, and thereby place before the world a consecutive map of this unknown region.

NOTE FROM KEW ON THE COLLECTION OF PLANTS.

"The botanical collection, although more numerous in species than that made in the Hadramut, comprising about 250 species as against 150 from the latter country, has less of a local character, and, as might have been expected, exhibits a larger proportion of species having an eastern extension. Apparently it contains no new generic type; but as the plants have not yet been thoroughly examined, some one of the obscure-looking things may prove to be such. Certain it is, however, that there is no very striking novelty of this rank, and the number of new species will not be very great. The most interesting feature in the collection is the presence of specimens of several plants of more than ordinary importance in relation to their products or distribution. Noteworthy among these are the wild cotton, *Gossypium Stocksii*, and excellent specimens of the frankincense, *Boswellia Carteri*. This species of cotton was previously only known from Sind; and the specimens of frankincense prove Carter to have been right about the species from this region, though the fragments Kew previously possessed were insufficient to place the fact beyond doubt. The present specimens are exactly like those collected by Playfair and Hildebrandt in Somaliland. *Balsamodendron Opobalsamum*, one of the myrrhs, is also in the collection. *Acridocarpus Orientalis*, a very conspicuous member of the Malpigiaceæ, was found at the foot of the Dhofar mountains. It is interesting, because it was originally collected by Aucher Eloy, but the locality was uncertain. He probably collected it in the Muskat district. *Gypsophila montana*, a wiry herb of the Caryophyllaceæ, is an illustration of that element of the flora common to Aden, Sokotra and Somaliland.

"W. B. H."

Before the reading of the paper, the Chairman, Admiral WHARTON (Vice-President), said: It requires no words from me to introduce to this Society Mr. Theodore Bent, who has so often delighted audiences here, and I hope he is going to do so again to-night. Mr. Bent has had many difficulties to contend with, and he has been disappointed in not being able to accomplish all he has wished, but I feel certain his paper will prove very interesting, and I will now call upon him to read it.

After the paper, Sir WILLIAM FLOWER said: I am asked to say a few words, but I am sorry to say that Mr. Bent has not given me the slightest opening to say anything about his paper. He has been to a most interesting country, and he has told us he has collected plants, and I congratulate Mr. Thiselton Dyer, of Kew, for having the opportunity of seeing something of the flora of the country. But he has not mentioned a single creature—except I think I heard him speak of a wild duck—in the animal kingdom, about which I can have anything to say. Of course it is impossible that a man can do everything, and such explorers as Mr. Bent must first go and open out these unknown countries, and naturalists will follow afterwards. I am sure that in a country so full of beautiful vegetation as this, there

must be a variety of interesting animals. In Mr. Bent's previous journey he had a collector of zoological specimens, and he brought back many of great interest; but I am afraid that the experience of taking the zoological collector was not on the whole, so far as the geographical results of the expedition were concerned, very satisfactory, and so Mr. Bent informed me, to my regret, before he went on this journey, that he should not impede himself with such a person again. Well, I suppose he was right, because, as I say, no man can do everything at once, and, although I have had no opportunity of saying anything in reference to my particular subject, I think I can say, as no one else has got up to do so, that we all here feel great satisfaction and pleasure at the safe return of Mr. and Mrs. Bent from this interesting journey. We all feel that they have done a very great work of geographical exploration, because they have brought before us features of the country which are entirely new to very many of us. I had no idea that behind the arid rock-bound coast, as it always seemed, of Southern Arabia could be found these beautiful green and watery vales, the photographs of which remind us at times of some parts of our own land. I therefore feel that Mr. Bent has done excellent work. Moreover, he and Mrs. Bent have performed this work under circumstances of considerable danger. They have happily surmounted all these dangers. And we hope this is not—I will not say the beginning, because they have begun already a long time ago—but we hope that this is only a stage of progress reached in a work which may go on for many years yet, and I am sure that geographical science, and with it the progress of humanity and civilization, will be very much forwarded by their exertions.

The CHAIRMAN: Mr. Bent has not taken us over a very large extent of country this time, but he has taken us to a very interesting one—to the home of the old frankincense trade, of which history scarcely knows the beginning. He is very much to be congratulated, I think, although he had difficulties that prevented him going in other directions where he wished to, that he found this country open; because the last account we had of it was, that you could not venture more than half a mile beyond the beach, and the inhabitants were always internecinely engaged in killing one another, and two men of different villages had to get an intermediary to allow them to talk to one another. Mr. Bent has happily come after the beneficent rule of Wali Suleiman, who has made his strong hand felt there, and who has opened the country up. I think there is nothing more interesting than going through a country with a history and endeavouring to recognize the old sites, and I think Mr. Bent has unearthed the harbour that must have existed in ancient days when the frankincense was more sought after than now, and when the trade was very much greater. Whether it could be made of any service now is another question. Mr. Bent seems to think it might be, and it is very possible it may be so. I am sorry that on the maps we have here, Al Balad, the ruins of which he has discovered, is not marked. It is to the westward of Al Hafa, and I think there is no doubt that that was the old centre of civilization in this region. I think, ladies and gentlemen, you will all join with me in heartily thanking Mr. Bent for the very interesting information that he has given us in his paper.
